

FREE SAMPLE

Cockatoo Care Package

The first 6 pages of the 46-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, Is a Cockatoo Right for You? The Honest Test, Which Cockatoo: Size, Price, Noise & Temperament. The contents page shows every one of the 46 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 40 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/cockatoo/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free cockatoo care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/cockatoo/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you have not bought a bird yet

Read page 5 first, before anything else in this book, and answer it honestly. It is the only page here written with the intention of talking some readers out of the purchase, and it exists because cockatoos are among the most frequently surrendered parrots there are. If you get through it and still want one, page 6 decides *which* cockatoo, which changes the price, the noise, the cage and the lifespan more than most buyers expect. Then read section 02 and section 03 before you buy anything, and use page 34 so you buy once.

If your cockatoo is already home

Start with page 16, because short daily training sessions are the most useful habit in this book: structured attention is what a cockatoo needs most, and no toy supplies it. Then page 15 and page 9. If the bird screams, plucks or has become a one-person animal that lunges at everyone else, pages 18 through 19 are the ones to work through, and they work better before the behavior is entrenched than after. If anything looks physically wrong, go to Health Red Flags on page 23.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 32: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 33: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 41: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 31: Succession & Rehoming Plan |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Cockatoos are sold on the cuddling. A hand-raised baby cockatoo is one of the most affectionate animals anybody will ever meet, and almost nothing in a shop tells the buyer what that same bird needs at eight years old, or what happens when it does not get it. This book is written to close that gap: what the day actually looks like, what the noise actually is, what the dust does to a house, and what happens to the bird when you are seventy. Every figure is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on pages 44 and 45, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian, and for an entrenched behavior problem, a certified avian behavior consultant. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. This species has the highest concentration of serious behavioral problems of any commonly kept parrot, and the professionals who work with them exist for a reason. Find both before you need them and write the numbers on page 33.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Written around the umbrella cockatoo, with the range across commonly kept species. Page 6 splits them out.

Family	Cacatuidae, the cockatoos. Twenty-one species, of which perhaps six are commonly kept. The cockatiel is the smallest member of this same family
Reference species here	The umbrella cockatoo, <i>Cacatua alba</i> , from the Maluku Islands of Indonesia
Adult size	12 to 28 in (30 to 70 cm) across the family. An umbrella is about 18 in (46 cm)
Adult weight	Goffin's about 350 g, umbrella 400 to 700 g, Moluccan and greater sulphur-crested up to about 880 g. Page 6
Captive lifespan	25 to 45 years is typical , and the larger species reach 70 to 80 or more. Plan for a bird that outlives you. Page 31
Sexual maturity	3 to 4 years in medium species, 5 to 6 in large ones. This is when a sweet bird often becomes a difficult one. Page 17
Weaning	90 to 120 days in medium species, 120 to 150 in large ones. A bird sold unweaned is a red flag
Cage minimum	36×24×48 in (91×61×122 cm), with 48×48×60 in (122×122×152 cm) as the real target. Page 7
Bar spacing	3/4 to 1 in (19 to 25 mm) for a large cockatoo, on heavy-gauge stainless or powder-coated steel. Never galvanized
Perch diameter	3/4 to 2 in (19 to 51 mm), varied
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Darkness needed	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, every night. Page 9
Body temperature	About 106.2°F (41.2°C). Heart rate about 147 bpm (beats per minute) in a 500 g bird, breathing 15 to 40 a minute
Daily interaction	4 to 6 hours on most days. This is the number the whole decision turns on. Page 5
Noise	Among the loudest birds anybody keeps. Screams carry through walls, and quieting one is not an achievable goal. Page 19
Handling difficulty	Advanced. Not a first parrot, and not a second one either
Conservation status	The umbrella is Endangered on the Red List of the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature), the global list of threatened species. Several species are on Appendix I of CITES (the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species, the treaty that controls the international wildlife trade): its strictest list, for species threatened with extinction. Page 30

Cost overview

Getting started

The bird is **\$700 to \$3,000** for a common species, with umbrellas at \$1,000 to \$3,000 and Moluccans \$1,400 to \$3,500. A rescue fee is \$300 to \$800 and adoptable birds are not rare. Add cage, stand, toys, air purifier and a first vet visit and a realistic total is **\$2,200 to \$7,300**. Page 34.

Every year

Food is the small line. **Destructible toys are the big one**, because a cockatoo destroying them is the system working. Budget **\$878 to \$1,995 a year** including an annual exam. Across a 40-year life that is \$35,000 to \$80,000, before a single emergency.

THE REPUTATION IS EARNED, AND IT IS ON THE RECORD

A parrot behavior consultant who specializes in this problem reports that clients with cockatoos make up **more than half of her entire consulting practice**. Rescues routinely describe cockatoos as the bird they take in most. That is not a rumor about a difficult species, it is a measured pattern, and page 5 explains what causes it.

Is a cockatoo right for you?

The only page in this series written to change some readers' minds. Answer it before you buy, not after.

Cockatoos are extremely social, extremely intelligent, extremely loud, extremely destructive and extremely long-lived, and the combination produces more behavioral problems than any other commonly kept parrot. The bird is not defective. Screaming and plucking are, in large part, a direct readout of unmet needs. But it means the difference between a wonderful cockatoo and a tragic one is almost entirely what the household can provide, every day, for decades.

Nine questions. Answer them out loud.

QUESTION	WHY IT DECIDES
Can I give this bird 4 to 6 hours of real engagement most days?	Not company in the same room. Interaction. This is the figure behind the surrenders
Will that still be true in ten years, through a job change, a baby, or an illness?	The commonest surrender story is a life that changed, not an owner who stopped caring
Can my household tolerate screaming that carries through walls?	Dawn and dusk contact calling is normal behavior, not a fault to be trained out. Page 19
Do I own the building, or will a neighbor complain?	Noise is the second commonest reason a cockatoo is rehomed. Renting with one is genuinely hard
Is anyone here asthmatic or immunocompromised?	Cockatoos produce very heavy feather dust. Page 10 is not optional reading
Can I afford \$900 to \$2,000 a year, plus emergencies, indefinitely?	Chronic conditions in this species are expensive and common. Page 34
Am I willing to have my woodwork, furniture and baseboards destroyed?	Destruction is normal behavior. A bird with nothing sanctioned to destroy picks your house, or itself
Do I have a plan for the bird if it outlives me?	A 40-year animal needs a named person and money set aside. Page 31
Have I met an adult cockatoo, not a baby?	Babies are uniformly sweet. The animal you are buying is the one at eight years old

IF MORE THAN TWO ANSWERS ARE "PROBABLY"

Then the honest recommendation is a different bird. That is not a judgment about you. A cockatoo whose needs go unmet does not become a slightly worse pet, it becomes a screaming, self-mutilating animal in a spare room, and then it becomes a rescue's problem. The cockatiel, which is a small cockatoo and shares much of the charm, is a genuinely realistic alternative for a normal household. So is a rescue cockatoo you visit weekly rather than one you own.

Two things that make it work, and one that does not

- **A household, not a person.** A bird that accepts several people has several sources of company and does not collapse when one of them goes to work. Building this deliberately from day one is page 18, and it is the highest-leverage thing a new owner does
- **Structured time, not just presence.** Two short training sessions a day beat an afternoon on your shoulder while you work. Page 16
- **Not more toys.** They matter, and they are on page 15, but what a toy cannot supply is attention. No product substitutes for it

CONSIDER ADOPTION SERIOUSLY

Rescue fees run \$300 to \$800 against \$1,000 to \$3,500 for a baby, and adoptable cockatoos are not rare precisely because of everything on this page. An adult bird also shows you who it actually is, which a hand-raised baby cannot. A good rescue is honest about a bird's history, takes it back if it does not work, and is far more useful to you at year three than a shop will be.

SECTION 01

Which cockatoo

"Cockatoo" covers birds that differ by a factor of three in weight and ten in price. This decision comes before the cage does.

SPECIES	WEIGHT	TYPICAL PRICE	WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY GETTING
Goffin's <i>Cacatua goffiniana</i>	About 350 g	\$700 to \$2,000	The smallest commonly kept, and remarkable problem solvers. Less overwhelming in size and volume than a white macaw-sized bird, no less demanding in occupation. Chews relentlessly and escapes cages routinely
Galah Rose-breasted, <i>Eolophus roseicapilla</i>	300 to 400 g	\$700 to \$2,500	Often described as the most robust temperament in the family, and less prone to the extreme bonding. Genuinely prone to obesity, and named alongside macaws and Amazons in the veterinary literature for it. Page 26
Umbrella <i>Cacatua alba</i>	400 to 700 g	\$1,000 to \$3,000	The archetype of everything on page 5. Extraordinarily affectionate, extraordinarily loud, and the species most associated with separation-related behavior. IUCN Endangered
Sulphur-crested <i>Cacatua galerita</i>	Up to about 880 g	\$1,000 to \$3,000	Large, powerful, long-lived and extremely loud. The species the feather-plucking treatment study on page 16 was run in
Moluccan Salmon-crested, <i>Cacatua moluccensis</i>	About 850 g	\$1,400 to \$3,500	The largest and loudest of the commonly kept white cockatoos, and among the longest-lived, at 70 to 80 years or more. CITES Appendix I, which has real legal consequences in some states. Page 30
Palm <i>Probosciger aterrimus</i>	Very large	\$2,000 to \$16,000	Specialist keeping, specialist price, and outside the scope of a general care package. Named here only so you know what you are looking at

WHAT DOES NOT CHANGE BETWEEN THEM

Every commonly kept cockatoo is highly social, highly intelligent, loud, destructive and long-lived. There is **no low-maintenance cockatoo**. A smaller species buys you a smaller cage, a smaller food bill and a quieter bird by degrees, not a different animal. Do not read this page as a way around the commitment on page 5.

Where the bird comes from

SOURCE	WHAT TO KNOW
Rescue or sanctuary	\$300 to \$800. The bird's temperament is already visible, its history is usually known, and a good organization stays involved. The strongest option for most buyers, and the one this book recommends
A small breeder	Ask to see the parents, the weaning arrangements and the testing. A bird should be fully weaned before it leaves: 90 to 150 days depending on species. Hand-feeding an unweaned cockatoo is specialist work and a bird sold unweaned is a bird sold too early
A shop	The weakest option. Birds from multiple sources sharing air is what page 29 exists to prevent, and staff rarely know a bird's history

Hand-raised is not a free upgrade. The socialization to people is the appeal and is real. Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006) found hand-reared parrots also imprint on people and become socially dependent, with more aggression, feather picking and stereotyped behavior than parent-reared birds. In the species whose defining failure mode is over-bonding (page 18), that is worth knowing.

FOUR QUESTIONS FOR THE SELLER

Has it been tested for PBFD (psittacine beak and feather disease, a viral disease that destroys feathers and the beak), polyomavirus and chlamydia, and can I see the results? Is it fully weaned, and on what? Has it ever plucked, screamed persistently, or been returned? And will you take the bird back if my vet finds a problem in the first week? A seller worth buying from answers all four without hesitating.